



A+ LAB SERIES V5

Lab 3: Windows Customizations

Document Version: **2026-01-02**

Material in this Lab Aligns to the Following	
CompTIA A+ (220-1201) Exam Objectives	3.5: Given a scenario, install and configure motherboards, central processing units (CPUs), and add-on cards. 5.3: Given a scenario, troubleshoot video, projector, and display issues.
CompTIA A+ (220-1202) Exam Objectives	1.3: Compare and contrast basic features of Microsoft Windows editions. 1.6: Given a scenario, configure Microsoft Windows settings.

Contents

Introduction	3
Objective	3
Lab Topology	4
Lab Settings	5
1 Configuration Setting on Windows	6
1.1 Configure Desktop Property Settings in Win10-OS	6
1.2 Configure Desktop Property Settings in Win11-OS	10
2 Change Display Settings with Windows 10/11	17
2.1 Change Display Settings in Win10-OS	17
2.2 Change Display Settings in Win11-OS	20
3 Configure Taskbar Property Settings	24
3.1 Configure Taskbar Settings in Win10-OS	24
3.2 Configure Taskbar Settings in Win11-OS	27
4 Advanced Features Settings	31
4.1 Optional Features in Win11-OS	31
4.2 Advanced System Settings in Win11-OS	34

Introduction

Upon installation, Windows necessitates configuration and customization to align with the specific needs of the organization or individual user. These adjustments can significantly enhance various aspects of the operating system. Performance optimization, security reinforcement, and aesthetic modifications are common examples of such customizations. By tailoring Windows to individual preferences and organizational requirements, users can optimize their computing experience and mitigate potential vulnerabilities.

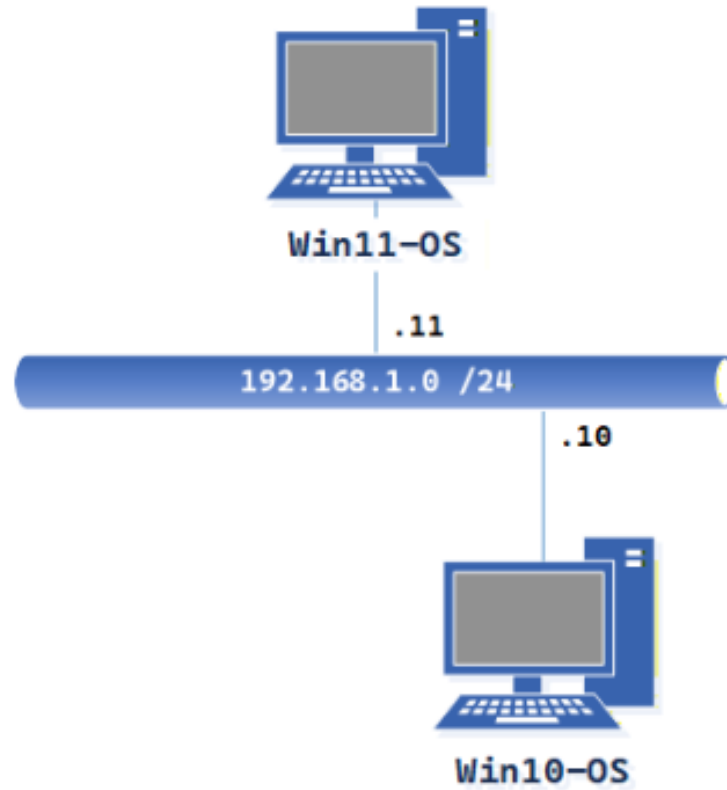
Objective

The tasks in this lab will explore Windows customization tools to improve performance, enhance security, and change the look and feel of Windows. Students will have an opportunity to explore a variety of these tools and review key concepts related to Windows customization. The tools vary by Windows version and edition, but in this lab, the focus is on those common to Windows 10 and Windows 11.

In this lab, we will be performing the following tasks:

- Using Personalization settings, configure the Desktop and Desktop Theme on Windows 10 and Windows 11.
- Change Display settings and colors for Windows 10 and Windows 11.
- Configure the Taskbar and Start Settings on Windows 10 and Windows 11.
- Explore Optional Features and Advanced System Settings for Windows 11.

Lab Topology



Lab Settings

The information in the table below will be needed to complete the lab. The task sections below provide details on the use of this information.

Virtual Machine	IP Address	Account (if needed)	Password (if needed)
Win10-OS	192.168.1.10 / 24	sysadmin	NDGLabpass123!
Win11-OS	192.168.1.11 / 24	sysadmin	NDGLabpass123!

1 Configuration Setting on Windows

Windows offers extensive customization, enabling users to tailor their operating environment to their preferences and needs. From modifying desktop aesthetics, such as backgrounds and icons, to adjusting system-level settings, including power management options and network configurations, Windows empowers users to personalize their machines in numerous ways. This adaptability ensures that the operating system can accommodate a wide range of user requirements, ultimately enhancing productivity and user satisfaction.

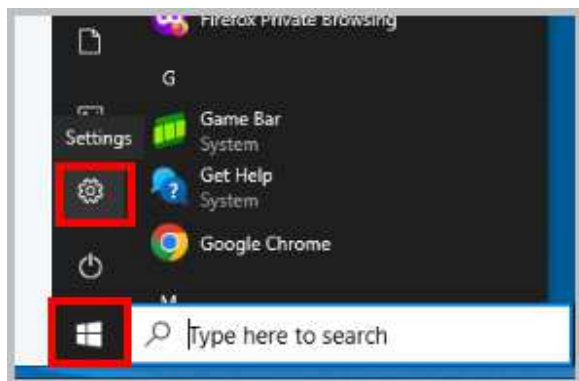
1.1 Configure Desktop Property Settings in Win10-OS

1. Open a console connection to the **Win10-OS** system.

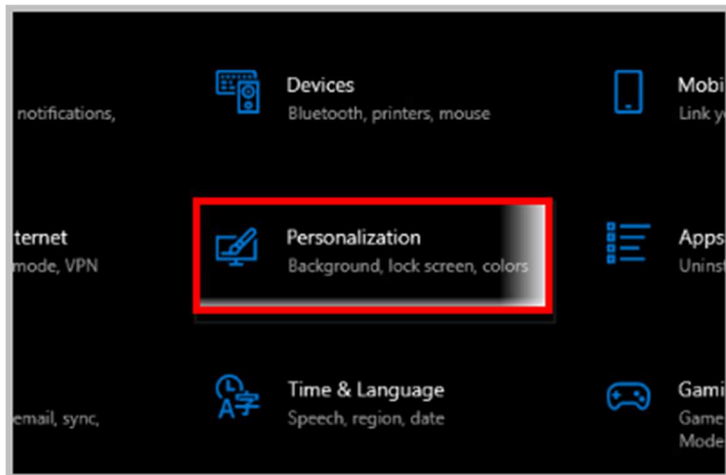


To launch the console for a lab device, you can click on the respective tab in the navigation bar at the top or navigate to the *Topology* section and click the lab device's corresponding image.

2. Click on the **Start** button and then click on the **Settings** icon.



- Click on **Personalization** to customize the look and feel of your desktop.

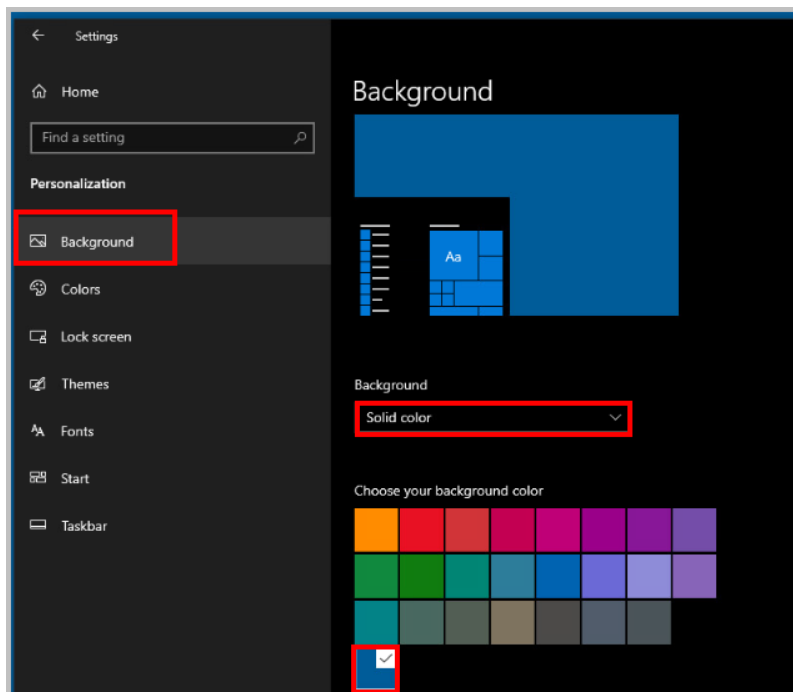


Challenge Task:

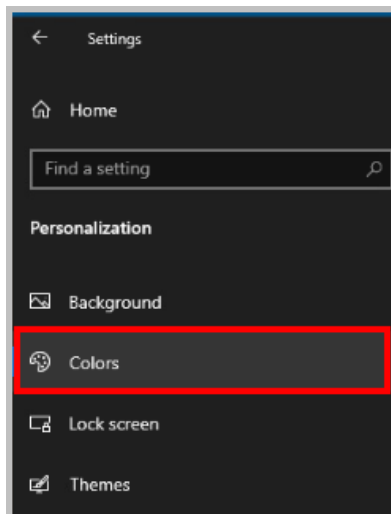
There are several options for customizing the look and feel in Windows 10 with desktop backgrounds, color accents, and a variety of settings to tweak the interface.

In this exercise you will be shown a few ways to customize the appearance and make the experience a little more personal and have an opportunity to continue the exploration further by experimenting with other menu selections on your own.

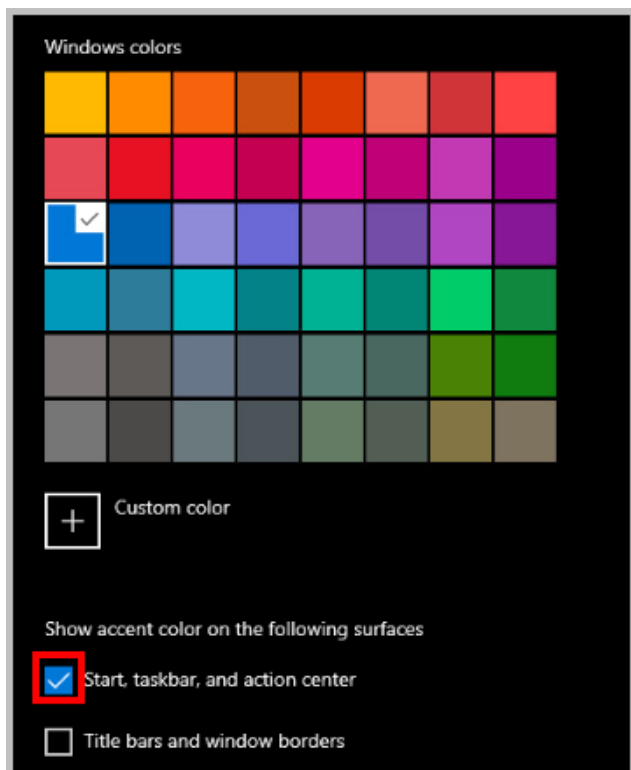
- Ensure that **Background** is selected from the left pane. Proceed by clicking on the **Background** dropdown menu and selecting the **Solid color** option. Click the background color you want to use.



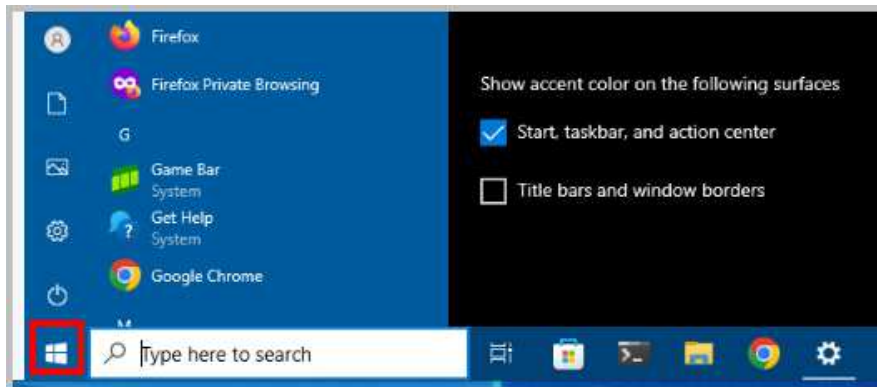
5. Click on **Colors** from the left pane.



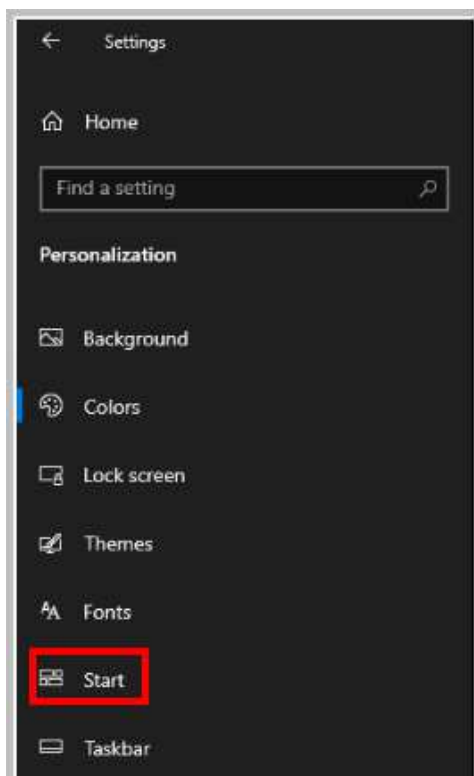
6. Here you can choose colors that affect things like the taskbar and the *Start* menu. Experiment by picking a color. Underneath the *Show accent color on the following surfaces*, select the checkbox for **Start, taskbar, and action center**.



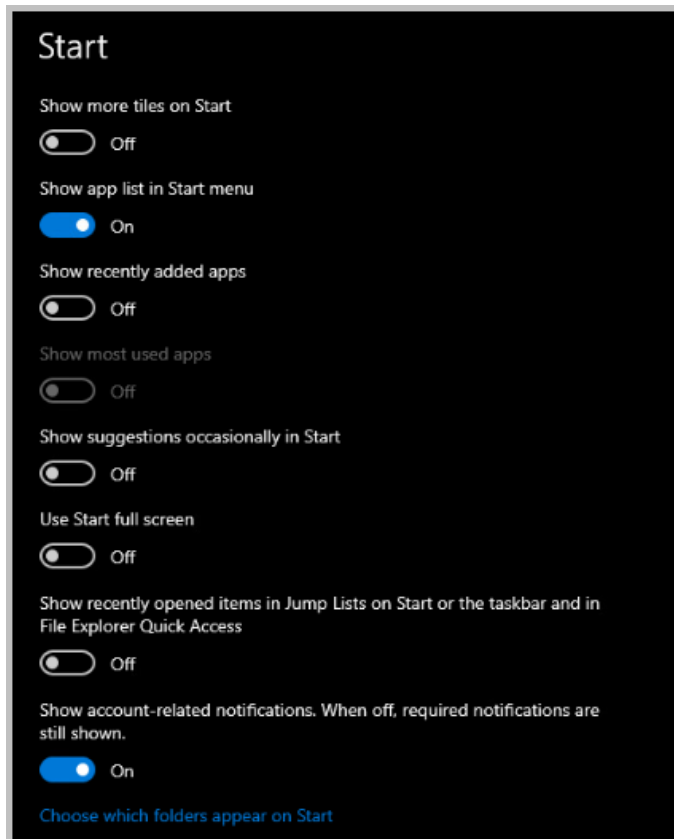
- Click on the **Start** button and view the color of the *Start* menu. Notice that the color varies depending on the color chosen for the *Start*, *taskbar*, and *action center* checkboxes. You can also notice right away that the taskbar changed color.



- Change focus back to the **Settings** window. Click on **Start** from the left pane.



- The setting options available here allow you to customize certain options for the *Start* menu, like choosing to show the *Start* menu in full-screen mode. Experiment with selecting various options to see how the *Start* menu changes and what your personal preferences are.



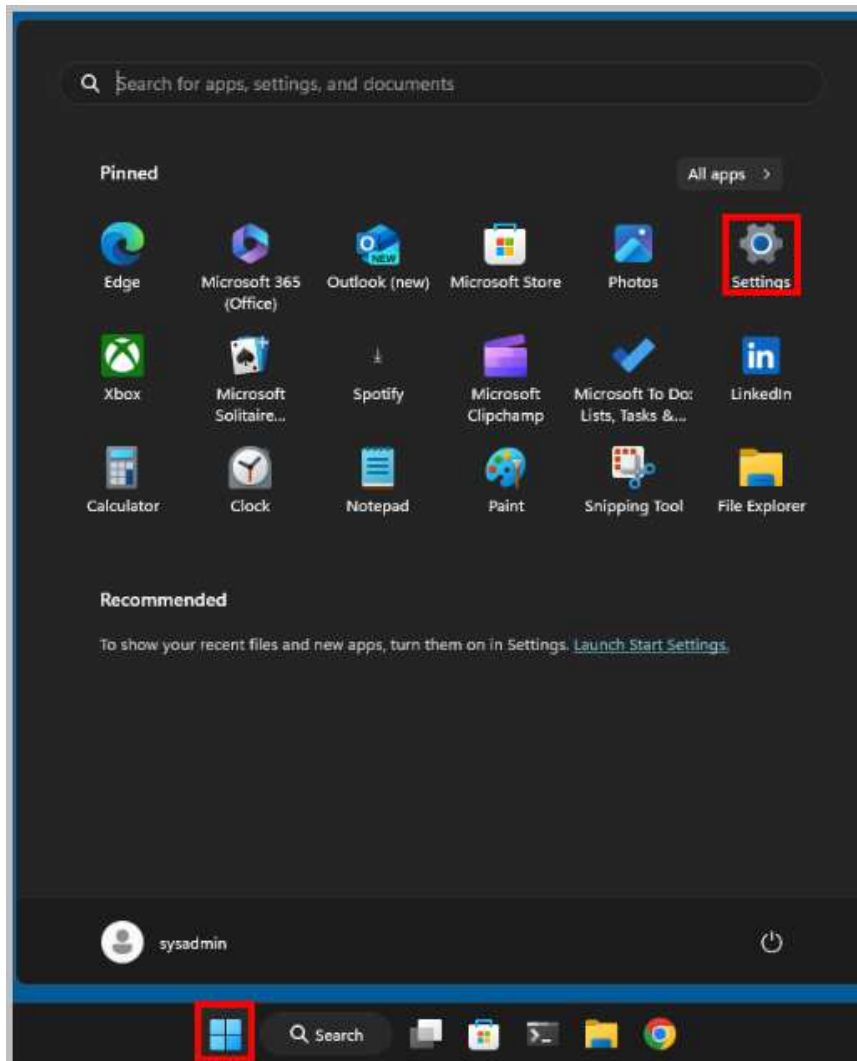
- Close each remaining window by clicking the **X** in the top-right corner.

1.2 Configure Desktop Property Settings in Win11-OS

- Open a console connection to the **Win11-OS** system.



- Click on the **Start** button and then click on the **Settings** icon.

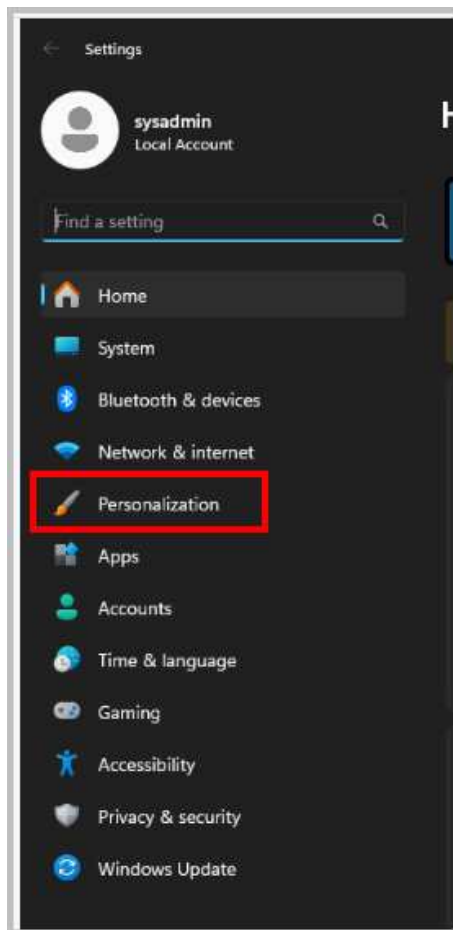


Challenge Task:

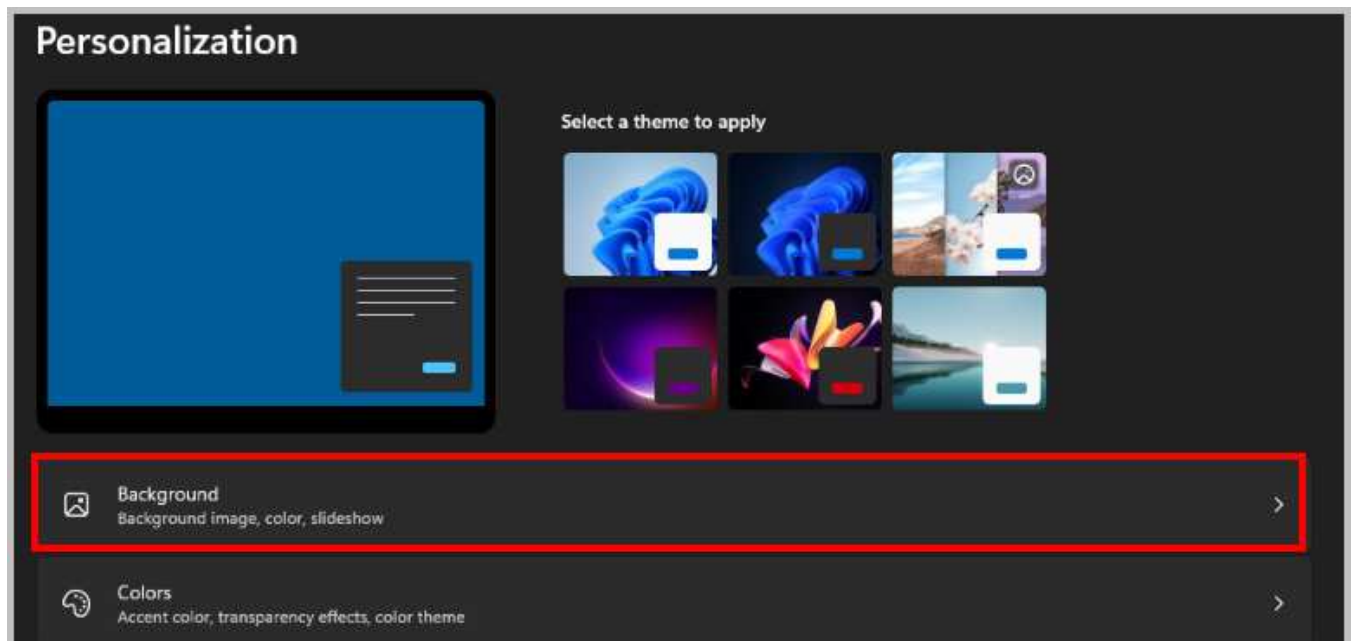
There are several options for customizing the look and feel in Windows 11 with desktop backgrounds, color accents, and a variety of settings to tweak the interface.

In this exercise you will be shown a few ways to customize the appearance and make the experience a little more personal and have an opportunity to continue the exploration further by experimenting with other menu selections on your own.

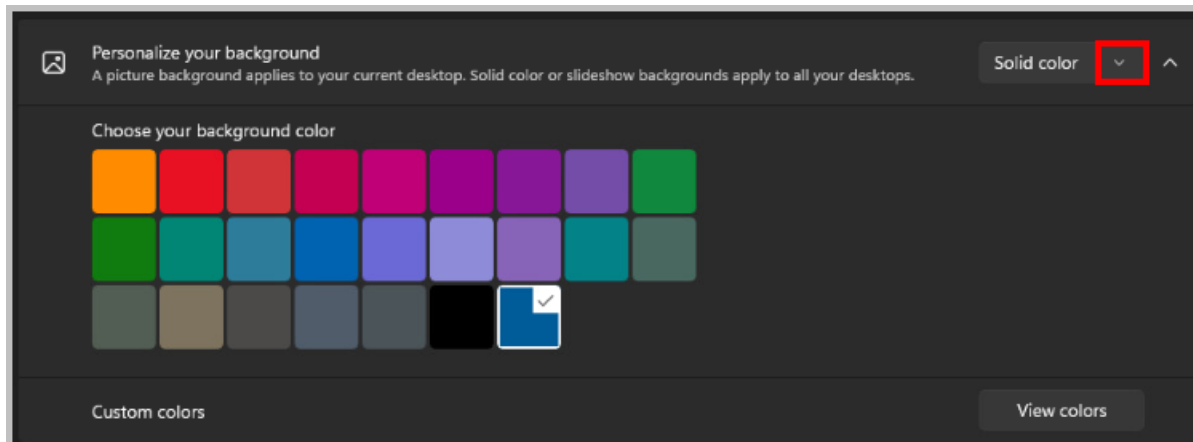
3. Click on **Personalization** to customize the look and feel of your desktop.



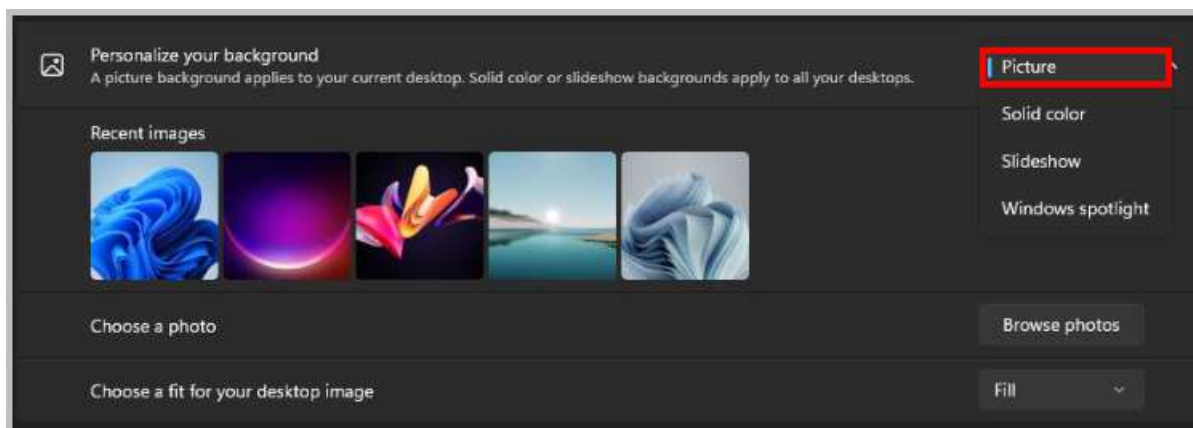
4. Click on **Background**.



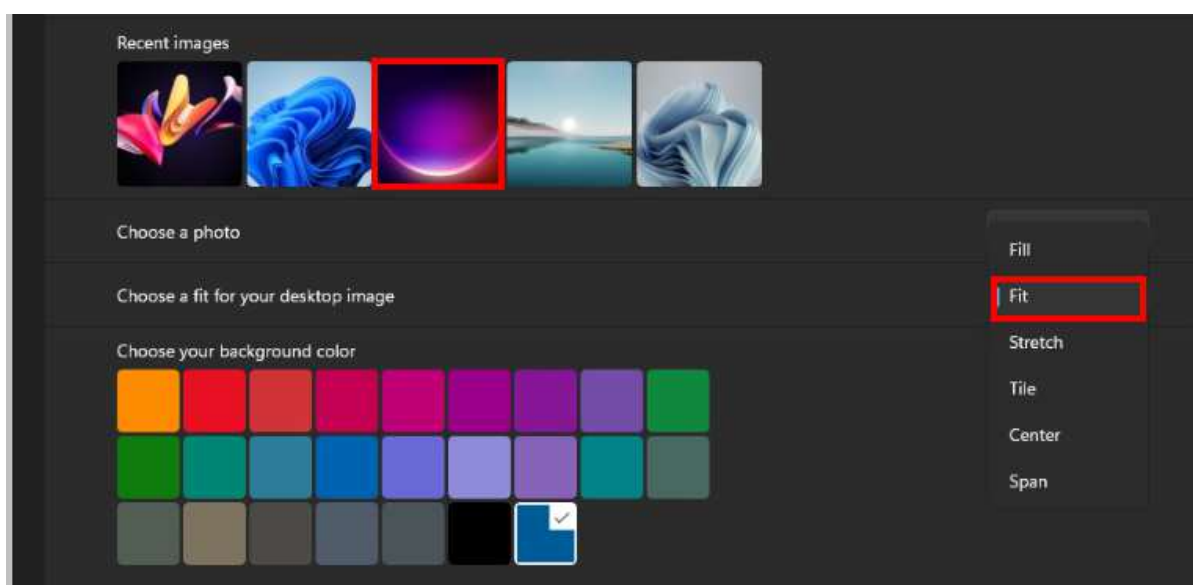
5. To personalize your Background, proceed by clicking on the **Background** dropdown menu.



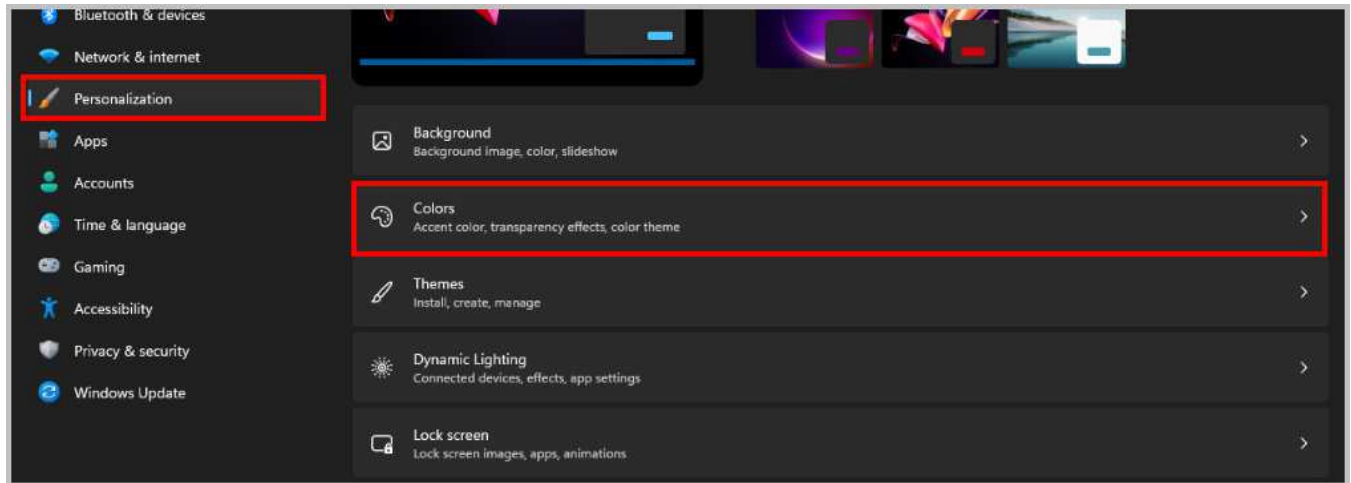
6. Select the **Picture** option.



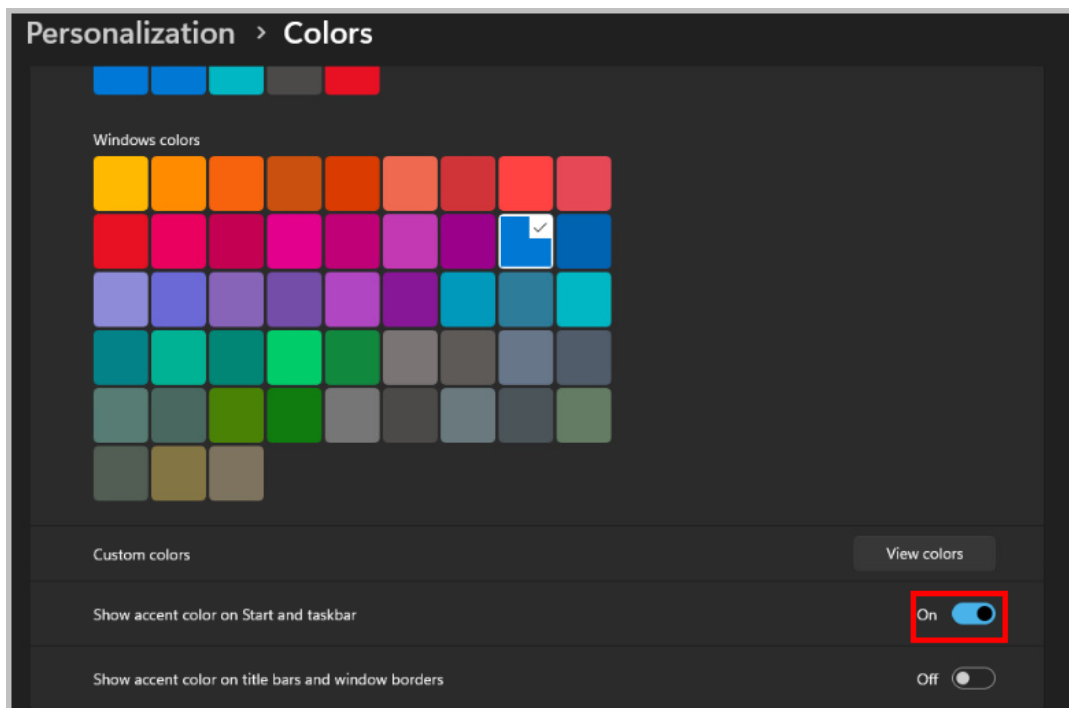
7. Click the image you want to use. Then click the **Choose a fit for your desktop image** dropdown menu and select the option that best suits the image (fill, fit, stretch, tile, center, span).



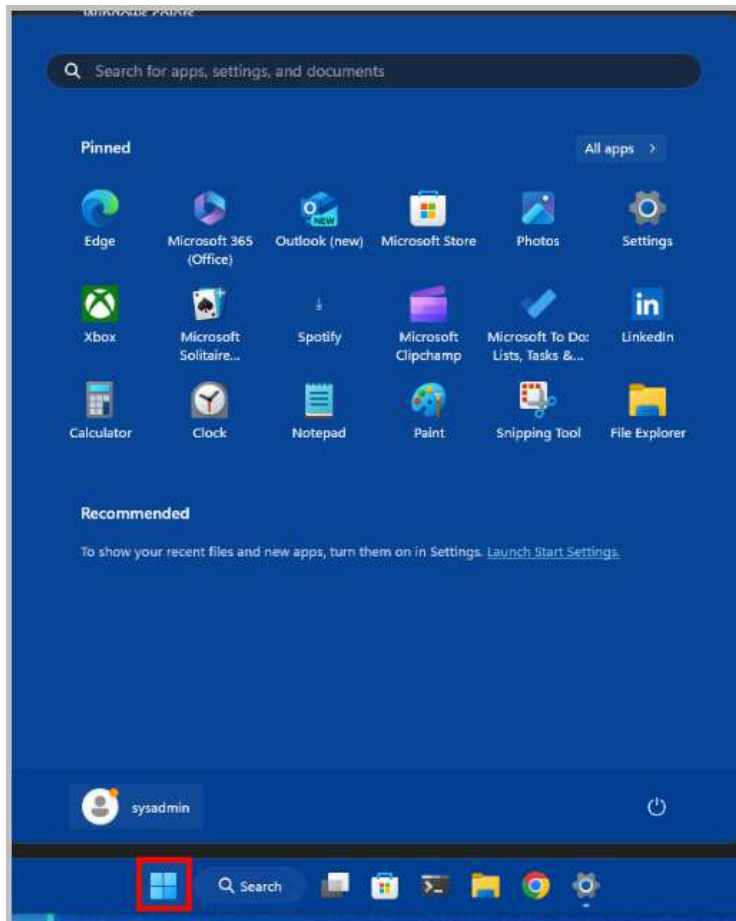
8. Click on **Personalization**, then select **Colors**.



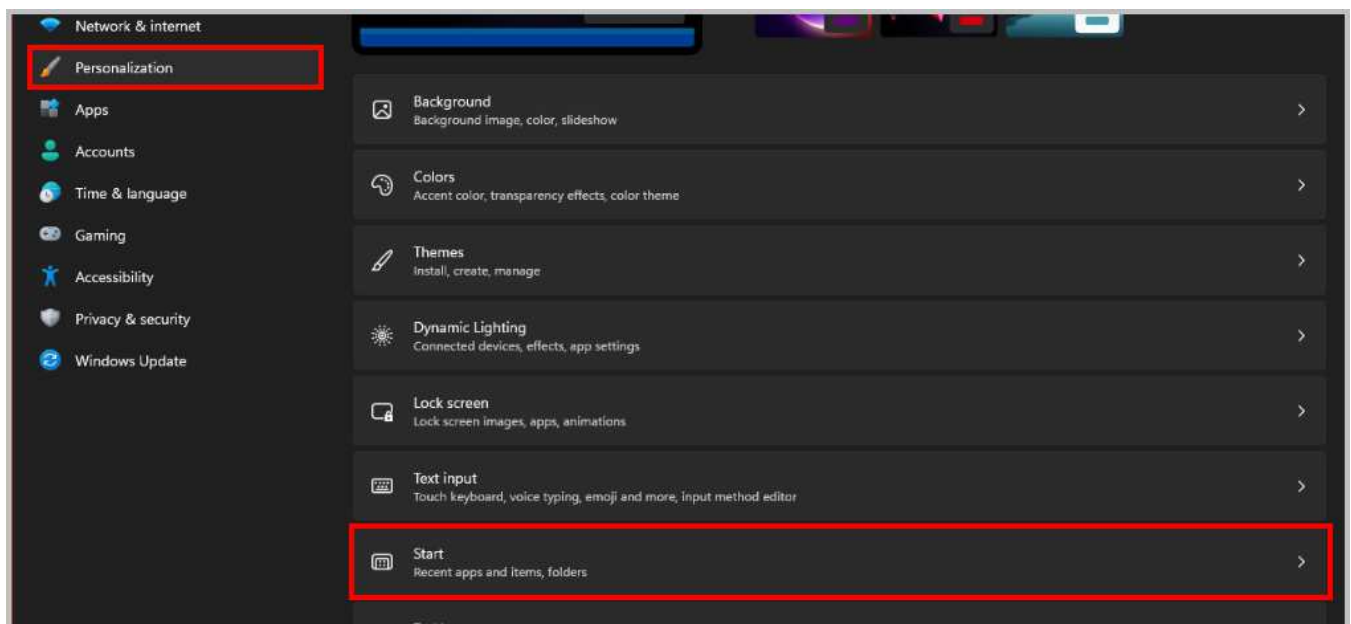
9. Here you can choose colors that affect things like the taskbar and the *Start* menu. Experiment by picking a color. Next to the *Show accent color on Start and taskbar*, select **Off** to turn **On**.



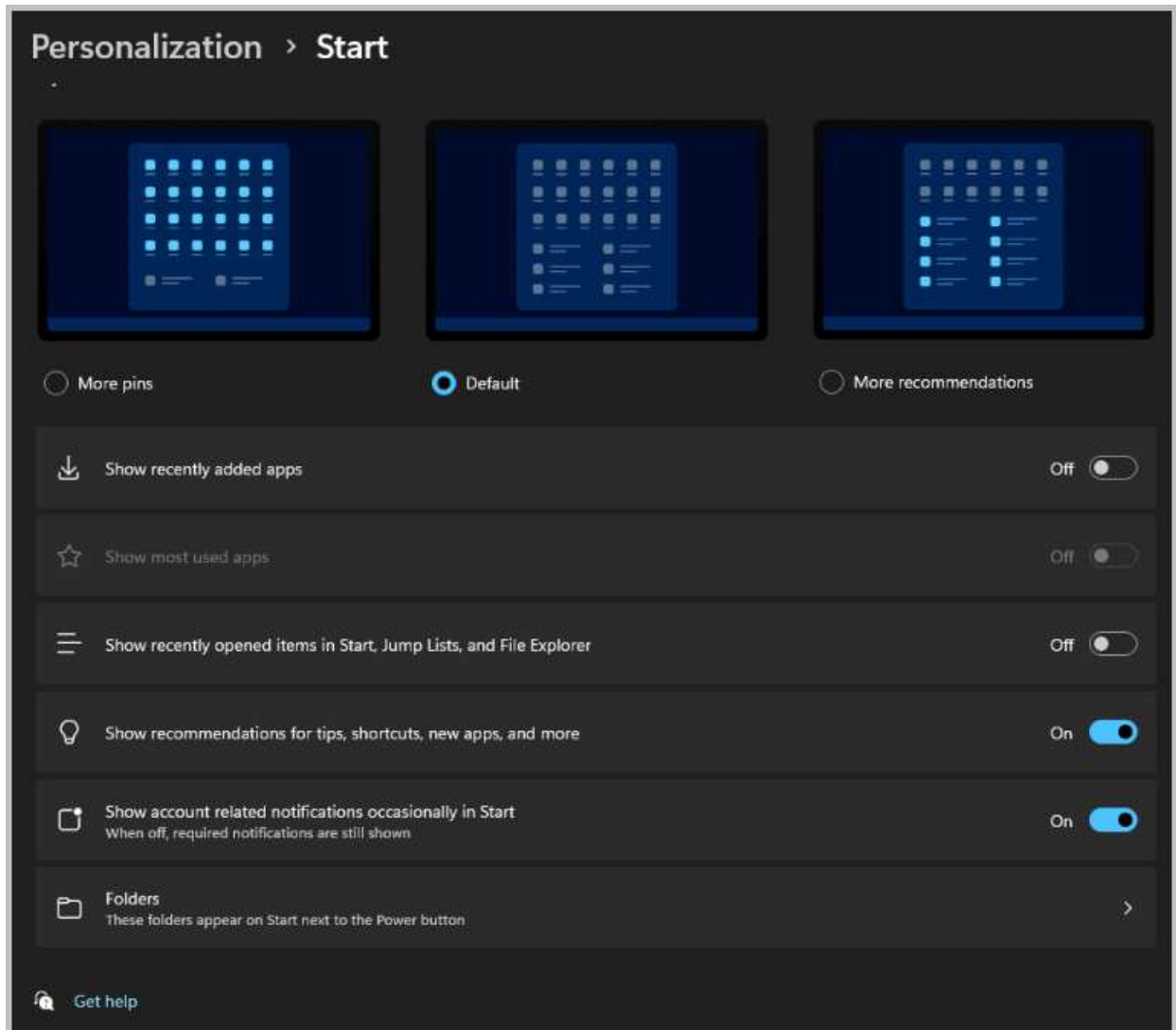
10. Click on the **Start** button and view the color of the *Start* menu. Notice that the color varies depending on the color chosen for the *Start and taskbar*. You can also notice right away that the taskbar changed color.



11. Change focus back to the **Settings** window. Click on **Personalization**. Click on **Start**.



12. The setting options available here allow you to customize certain options for the *Start* menu, like choosing to show the *Start* menu in Default mode, with more pins, or with the option of More Recommendations. Experiment with selecting various options to see how the *Start* menu changes and what your personal preferences are.



13. Close each remaining window by clicking the **X** in the top-right corner.

2 Change Display Settings with Windows 10/11

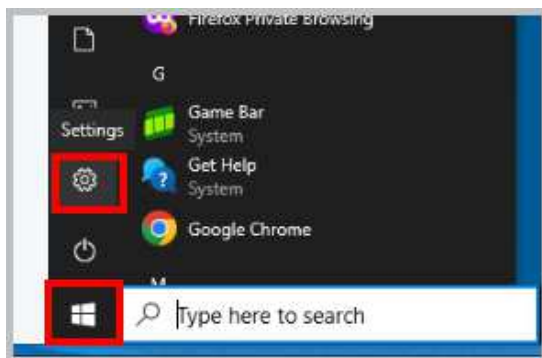
Changing display settings in Windows 10 and 11 is similar. You can access the display settings by going to Start > Settings > System > Display. Here, you can change your screen resolution, rearrange multiple displays, adjust brightness and contrast, and adjust the size of text and apps. You can also access advanced display settings, such as color calibration and color depth.

2.1 Change Display Settings in Win10-OS

1. Open a console connection to the **Win10-OS** system.



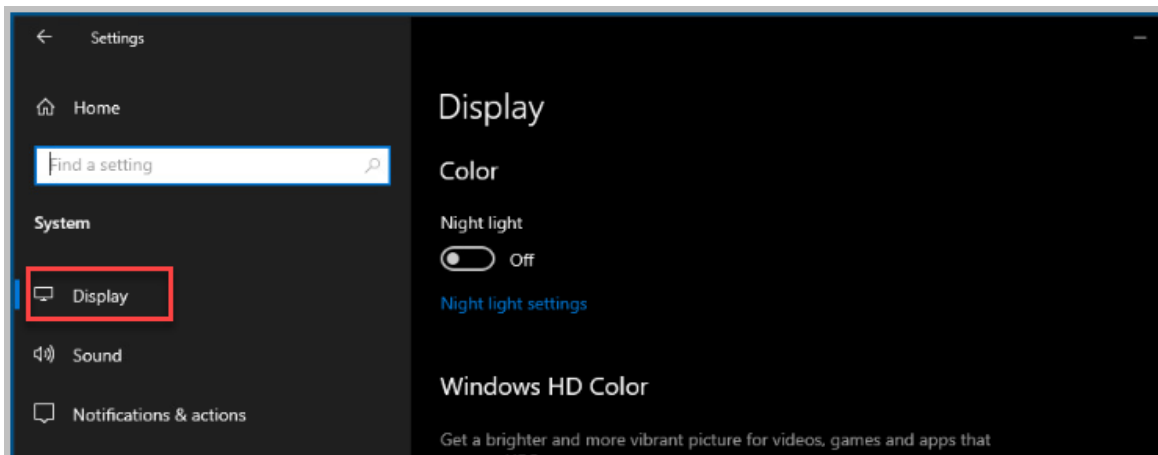
2. Click on the **Start** button and then click on the **Settings** icon.



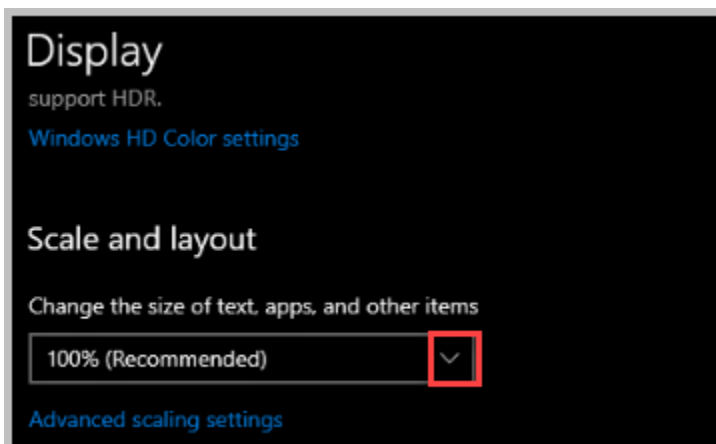
- Click on **System** to customize the look and feel of your desktop display.



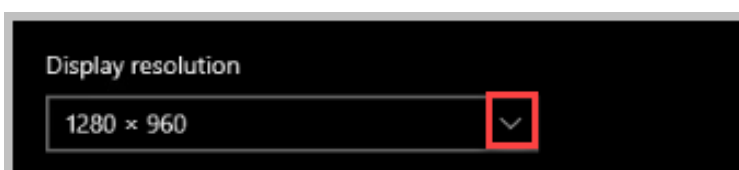
- Ensure that **System** is selected from the left pane. Proceed by clicking **Display**.



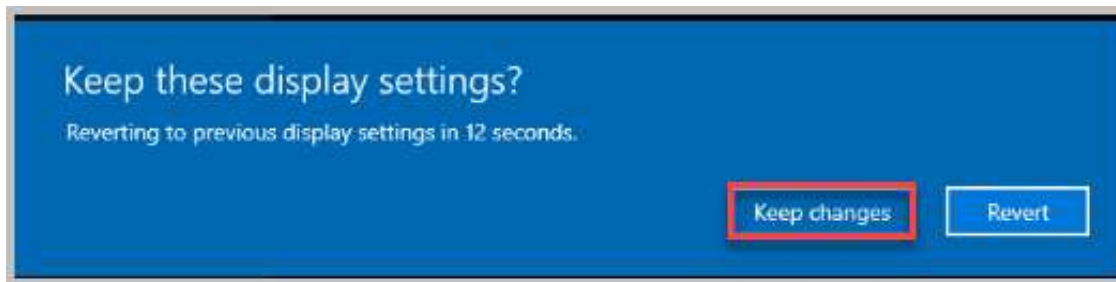
- In **Display**, change the size of text, apps, and other items by selecting the drop-down arrow and choose **125%**.



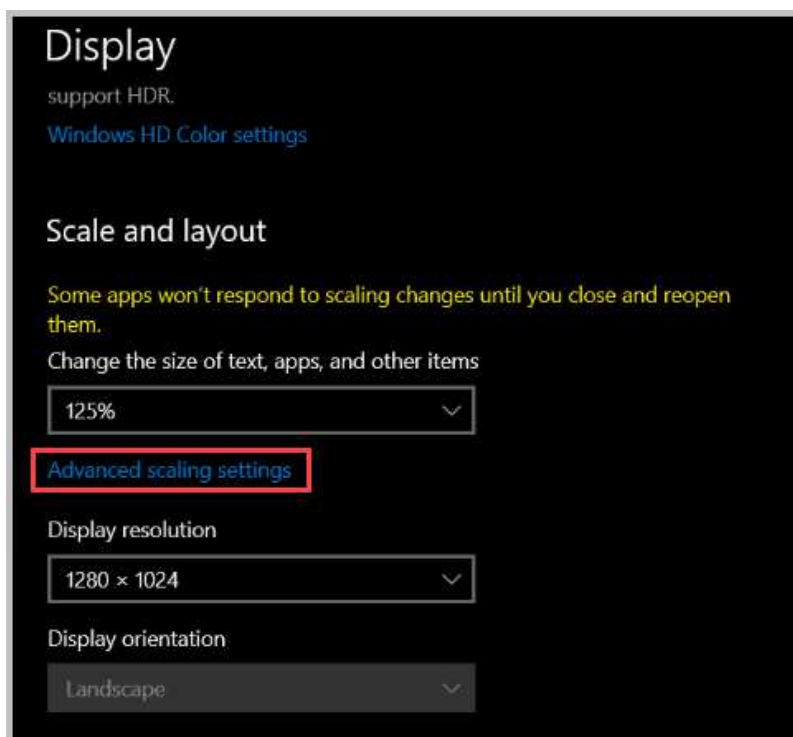
- Change the display resolution by selecting the drop down arrow to **1280 x 1024**.



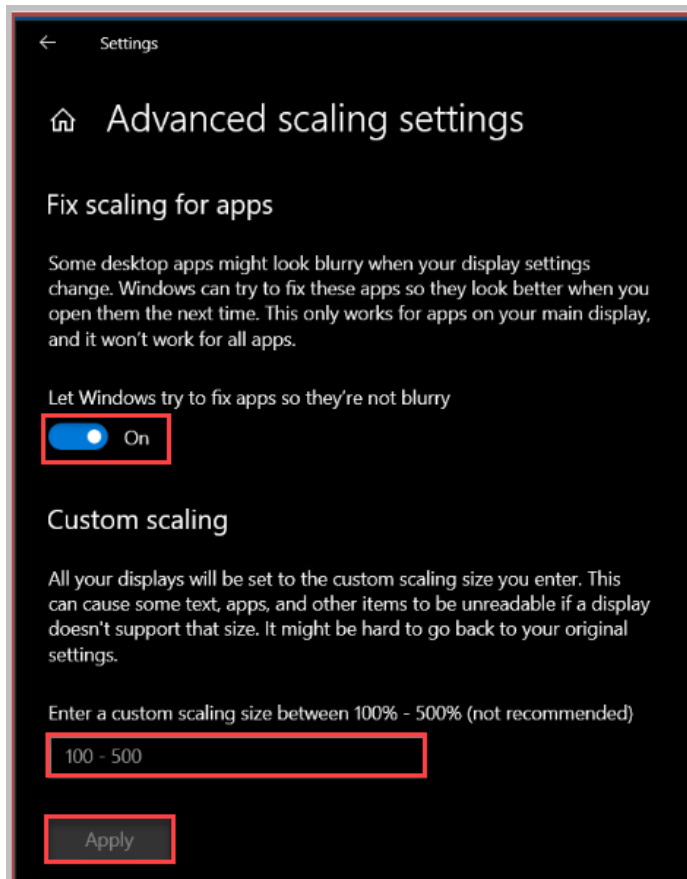
7. Select **Keep changes**, to keep these display settings in the pop-up window.



8. After changing the Size of text, apps, and other items, including the Display resolution, select **Advanced scaling settings**.



9. In *Advanced scaling settings*, by default, the option to *Fix scaling for apps* is enabled. If you would like to change this option or create Custom scaling, configure what works best for you and this lab. If you make any changes, you will need to select Apply for your selections to take effect.



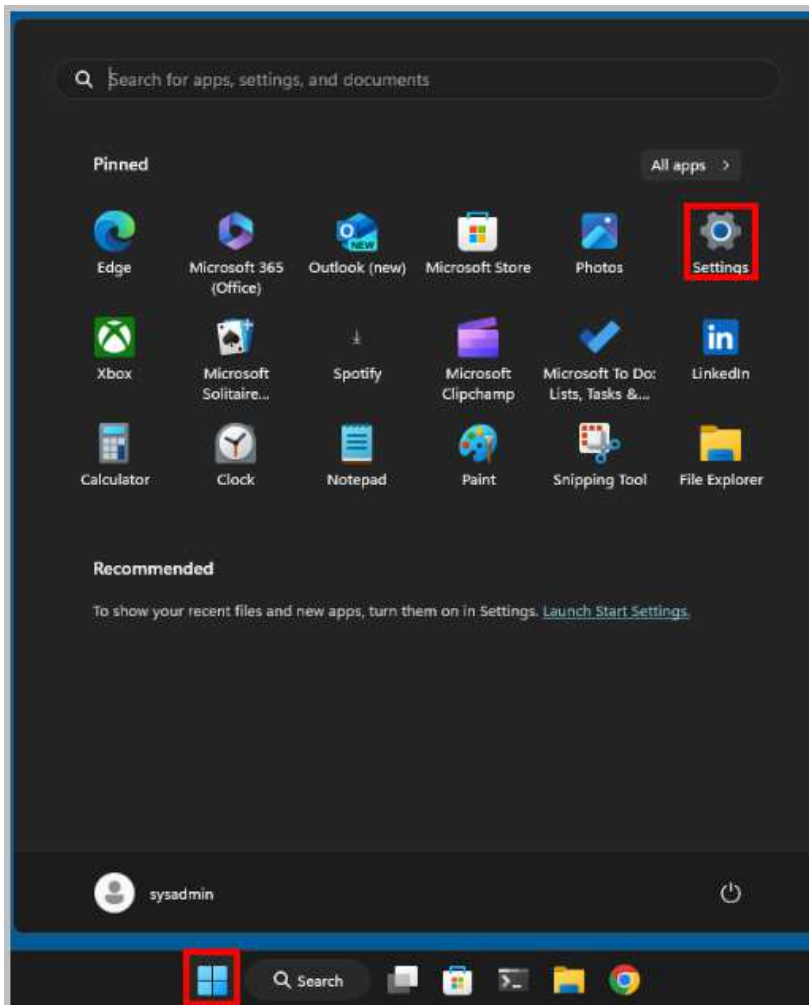
10. Close each remaining window by clicking the **X** in the top-right corner.

2.2 Change Display Settings in Win11-OS

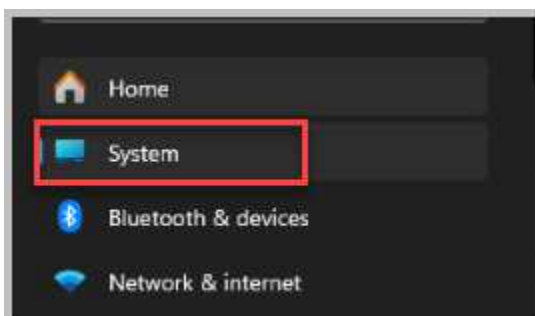
1. Open a console connection to the **Win11-OS** system.



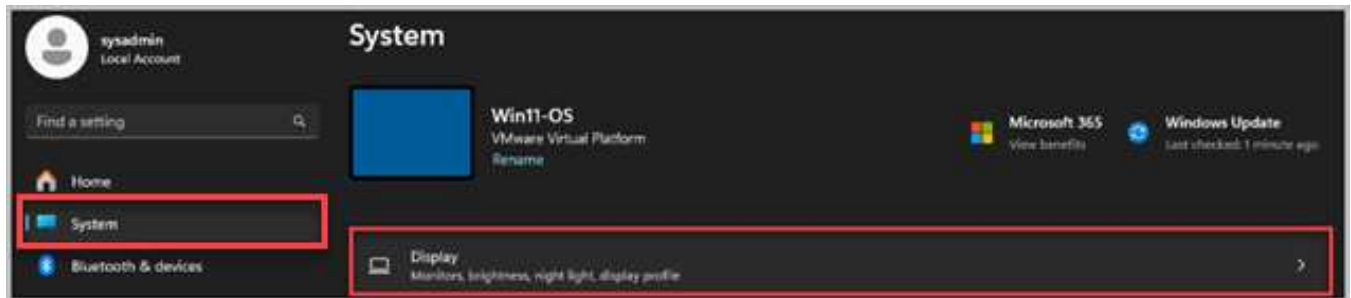
- Click on the **Start** button and then click on the **Settings** icon.



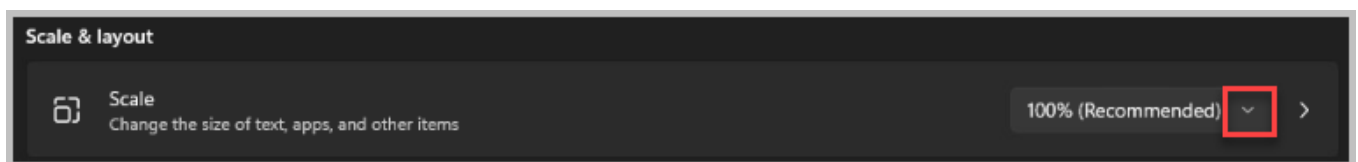
- Click on **System** to customize the look and feel of your desktop display.



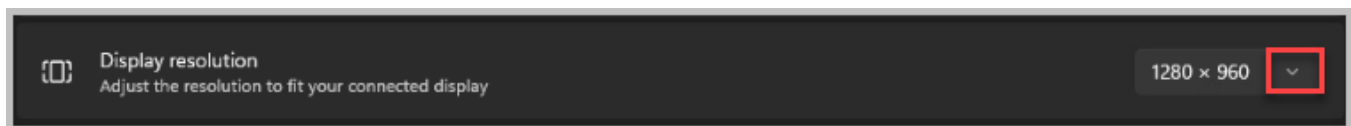
4. Ensure that **System** is selected from the left pane. Proceed by clicking **Display**,



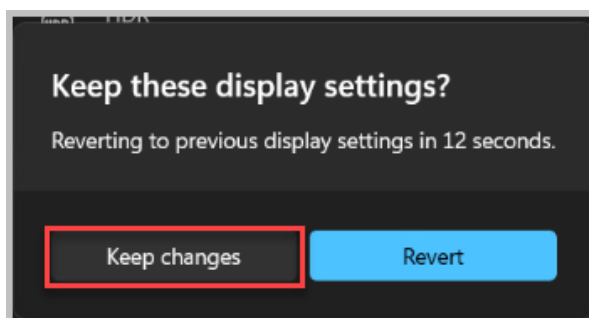
5. In **Display**, change the size of text, apps, and other items by selecting the drop-down arrow next to Scale and choose **125%**.



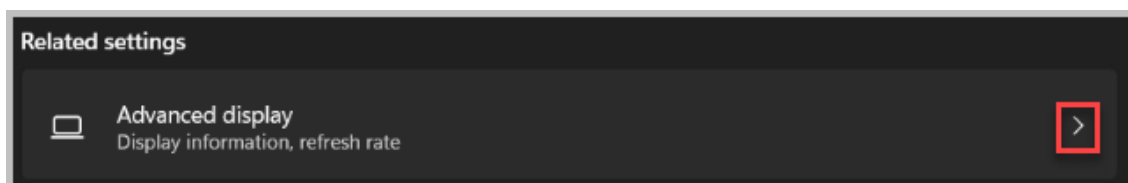
6. Change the *Display resolution* by selecting the drop-down arrow to **1280 x 1024**.



7. Select **Keep changes** to keep these display settings in the pop-up window.



8. After changing the Size of text, apps, and other items, including the Display resolution, select **Advanced display**.



9. In Advanced display, if there are multiple monitors, you could select the drop down arrow for Select a display to view or change its *setting* and select the monitor of your choice. As there is only one monitor, the only option is to view Display 1.



10. Close each remaining window by clicking the **X** in the top-right corner.

3 Configure Taskbar Property Settings

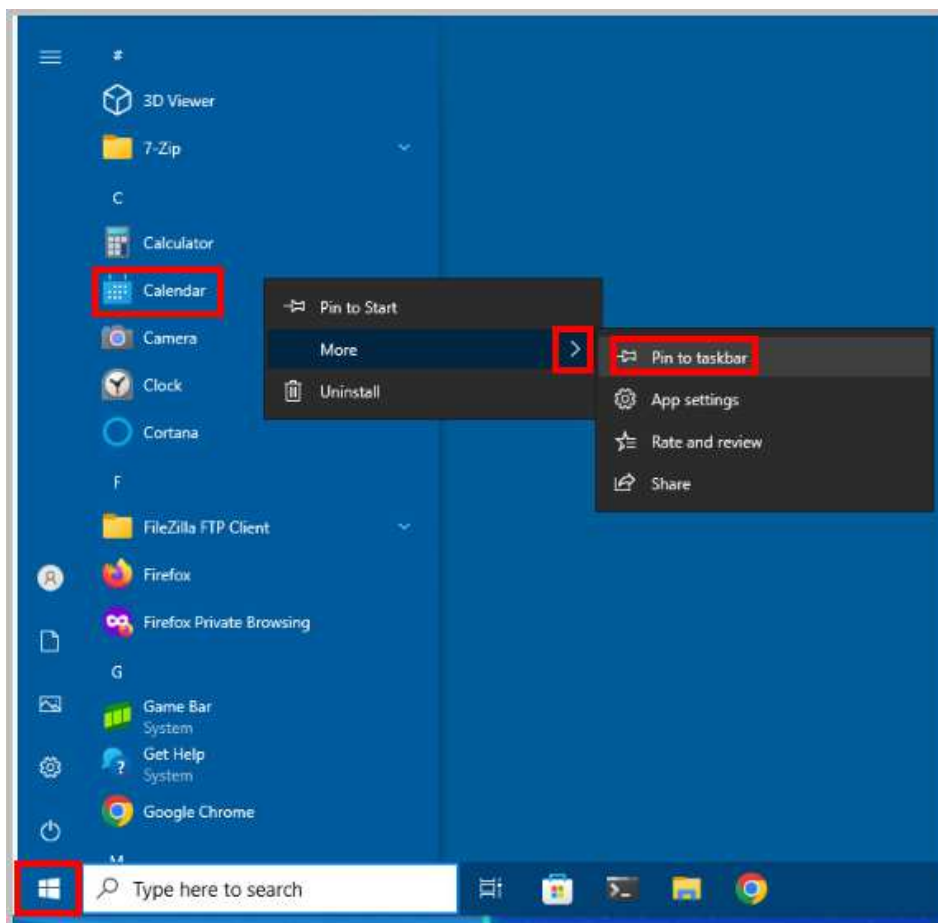
The taskbar is a fundamental component of the Windows operating system's user interface, providing a customizable platform that streamlines workflows. As a frequently used tool in daily operations, the taskbar's layout and features should be optimized to match individual preferences. Customization options include adjusting taskbar alignment, pinning frequently used applications, configuring system icons, and enabling or disabling features such as the search bar or task view. These adjustments allow users to access key tools and applications efficiently, improving overall usability and productivity.

3.1 Configure Taskbar Settings in Win10-OS

1. Switch back to the *Win10-OS* system.



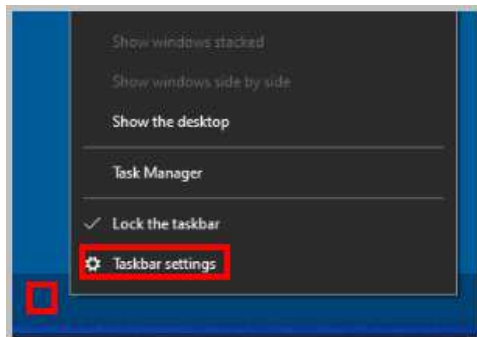
2. Click on the **Start** menu. Right-click on **Calendar** and select **More > Pin to the taskbar**.



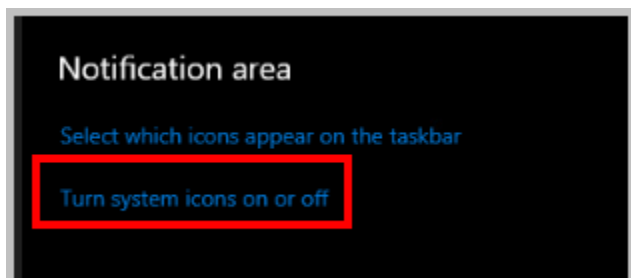
3. Notice the *Calendar* app is now displayed in the taskbar.



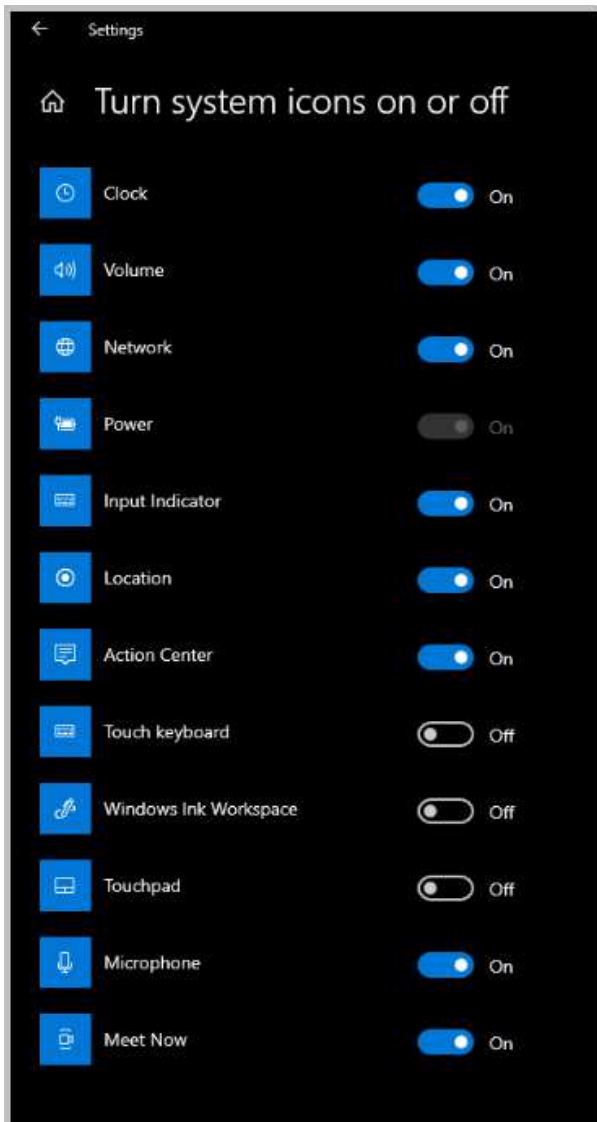
4. To modify the notification area in the taskbar, right-click any open area on the taskbar and then click **Taskbar Settings**.



5. Scroll down to the *Notification Area* section and click the **Turn system icons on or off** link.



- Review the list of system icons and toggle each one on or off to personalize it to your liking.

**Challenge Task:**

Continue to explore the taskbar right-click context menu for other customizations that will work for you.

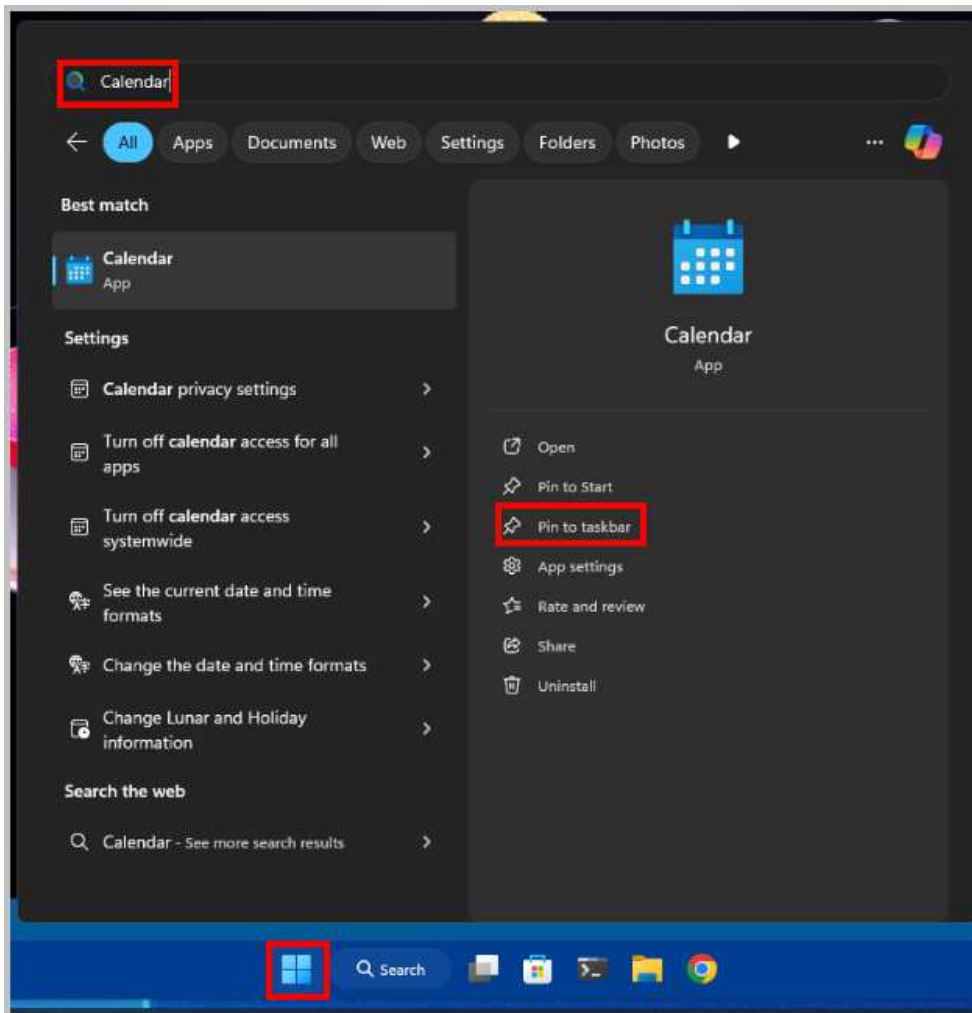
- Close each remaining window by clicking the **X** in the top-right corner.

3.2 Configure Taskbar Settings in Win11-OS

1. Switch back to the **Win11-OS** system.



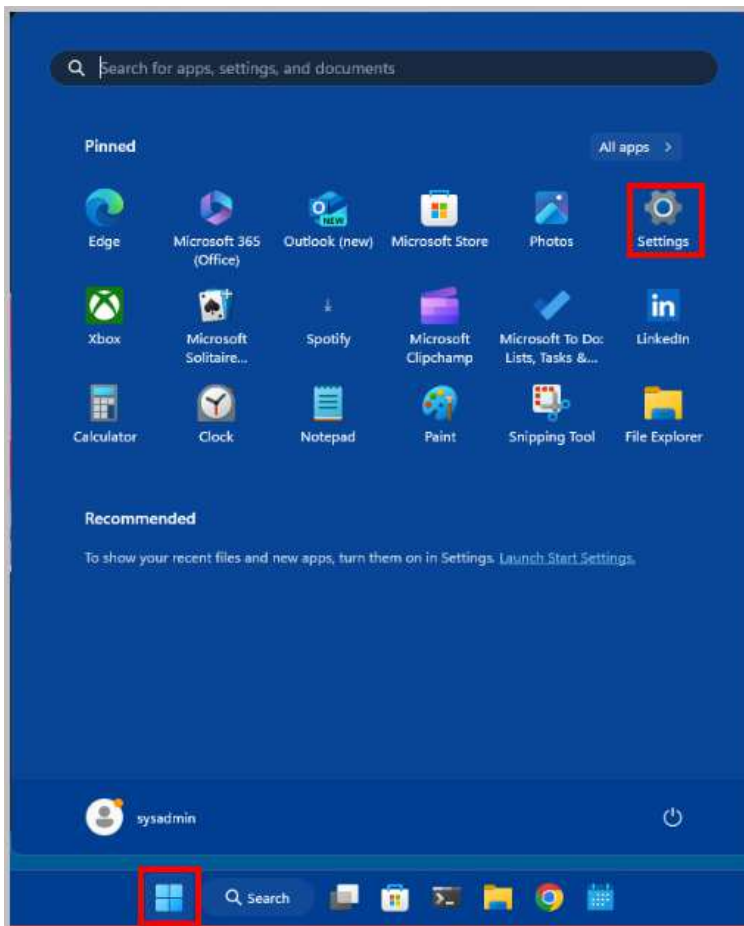
2. Click on the **Start** menu. In the Search box, type **Calendar**. Select **Pin to taskbar**.



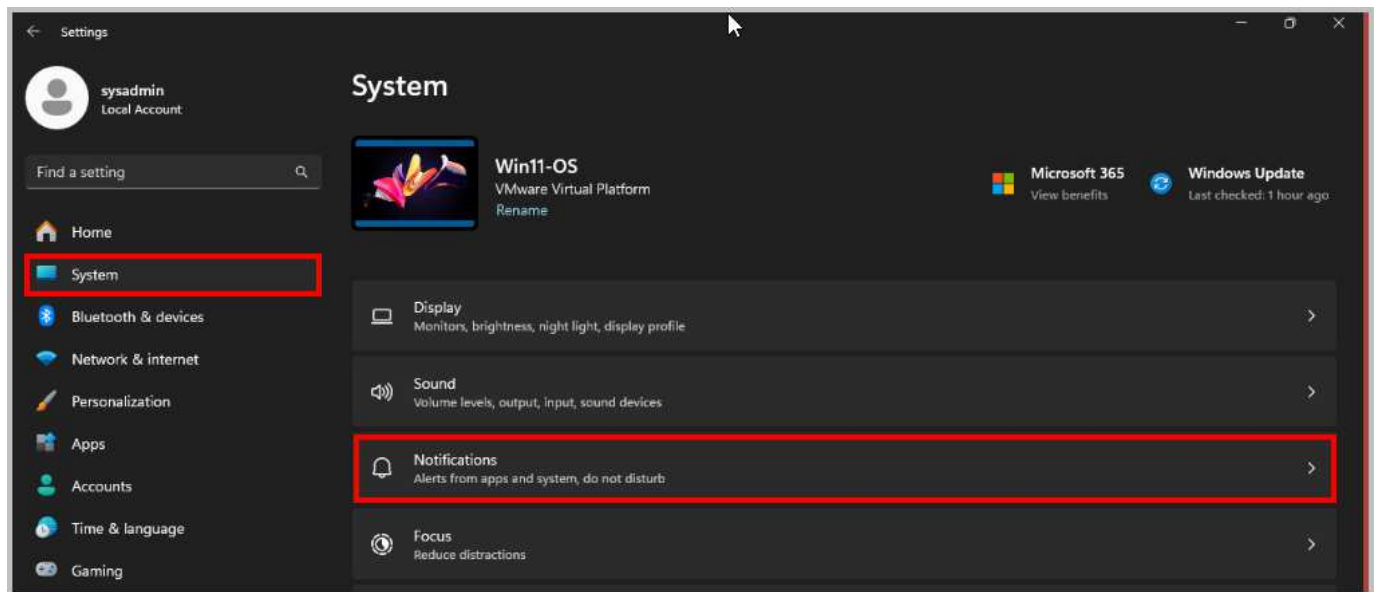
3. Notice the *Calendar* app is now displayed in the taskbar.



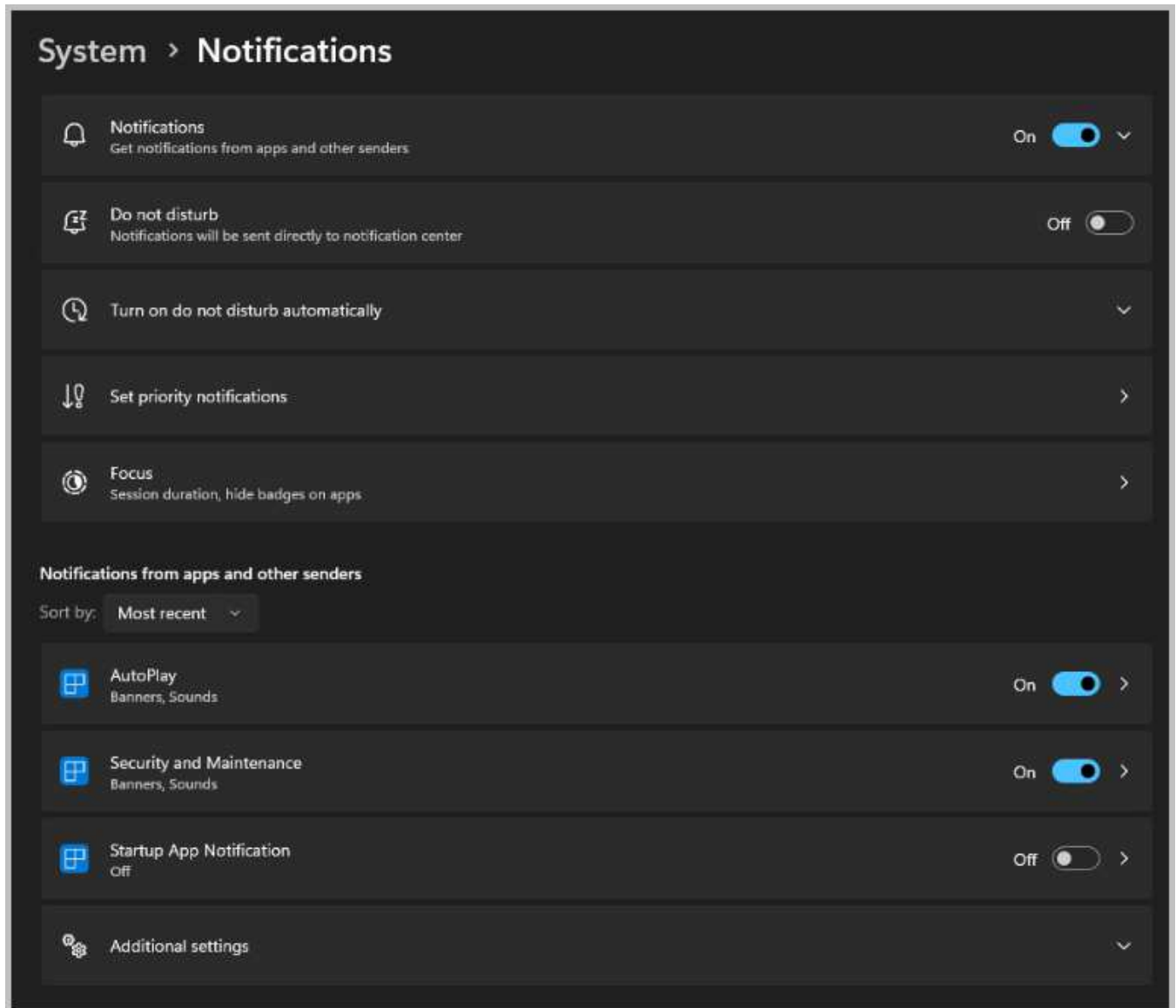
4. To modify the notification area in the taskbar, select **Start**, then select **Settings**.



5. Select **System**, then select **Notifications**.



- Review the list of options available and toggle each one on or off to personalize to your liking.



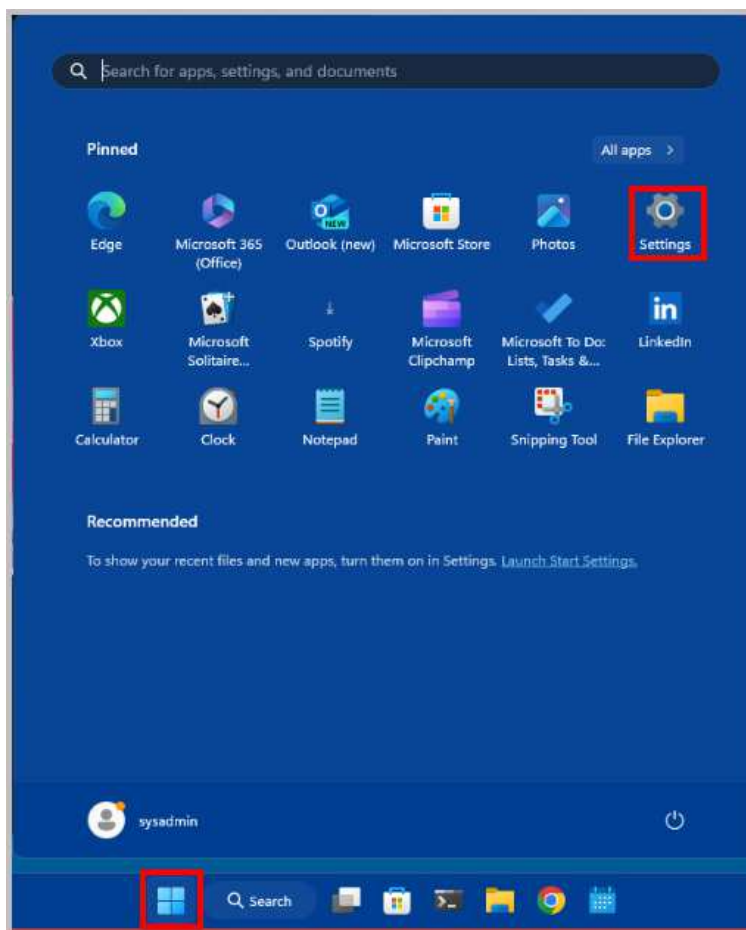
- Close each remaining window by clicking the **X** in the top-right corner.

4 Advanced Features Settings

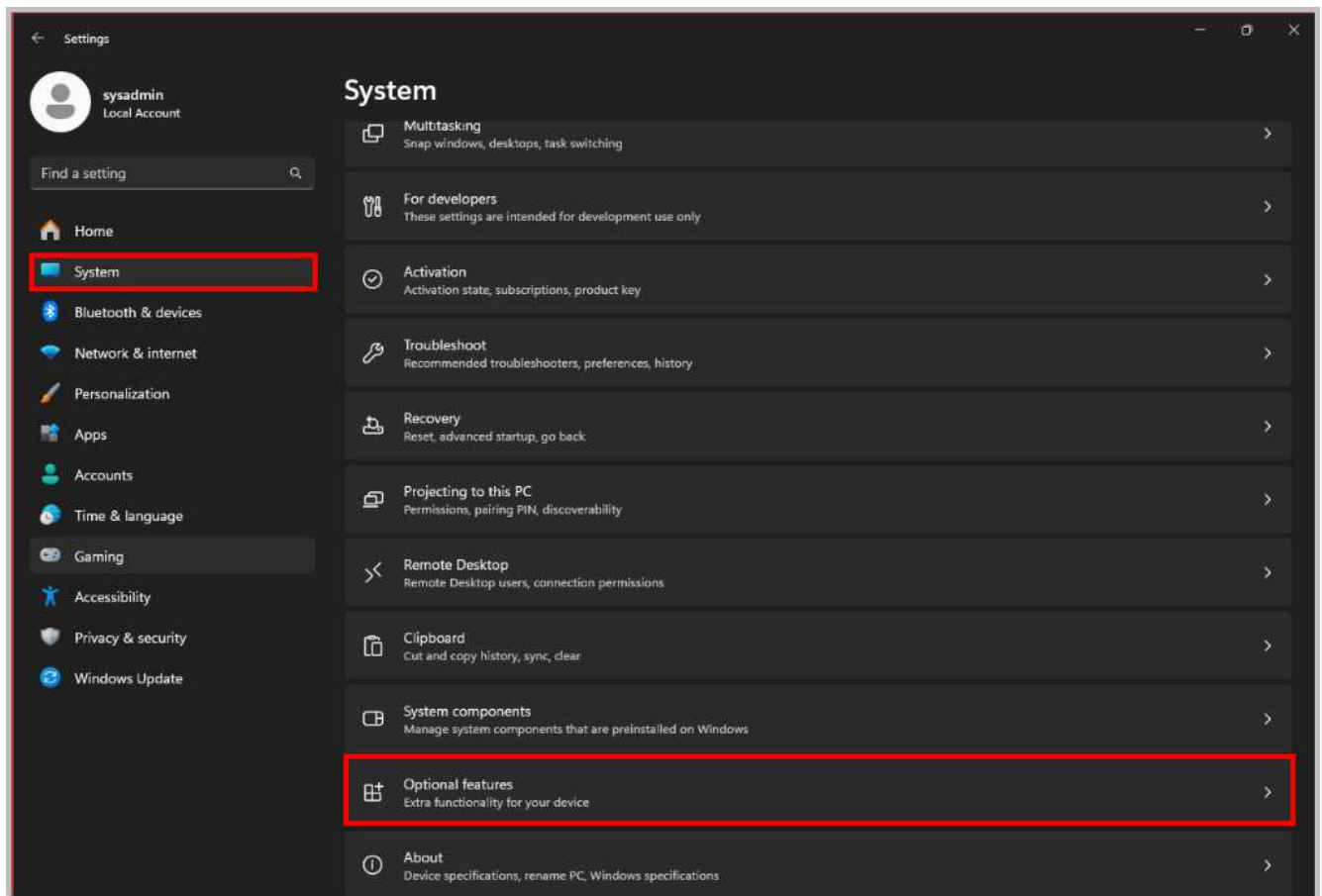
Windows 11 introduces a comprehensive suite of advanced feature settings designed to give users greater control over their system, enabling a highly personalized and optimized experience. These settings empower users to manage everything from system performance and security to hardware functionality and user interface customization. Whether it's configuring virtual environments, automating tasks, enhancing data protection, or fine-tuning system behavior for specific workflows, Windows 11 provides a versatile platform for both everyday users and IT professionals. With these advanced options, users can tailor their operating system to their specific needs, ensuring both efficiency and security across various computing environments.

4.1 Optional Features in Win11-OS

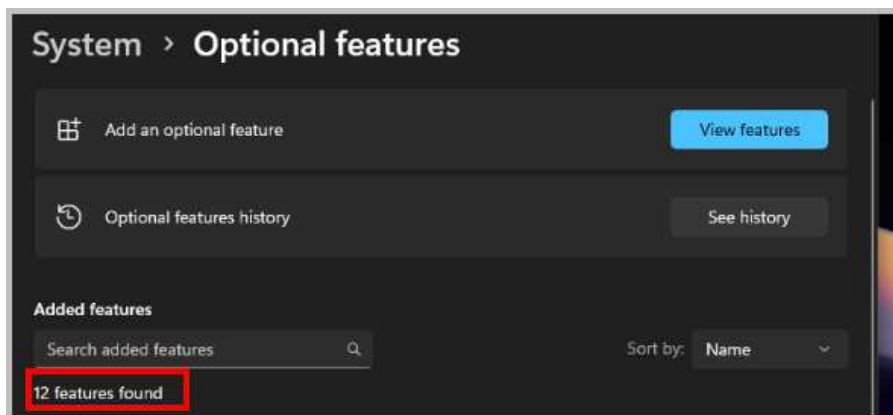
1. While on the **Win11-OS** system, select **Start**, then select **Settings**.



2. Select **System**. Scroll and select **Optional features**.



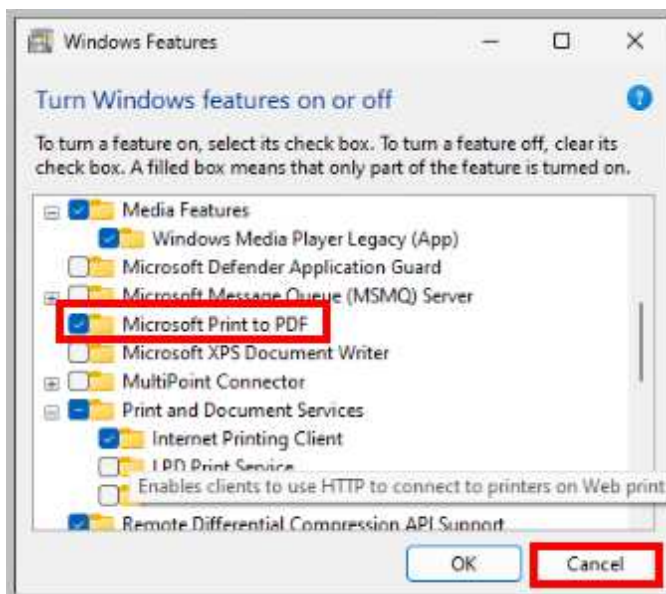
3. Notice there are 12 features already added.



4. Scroll through the features currently installed. After you have reviewed the features installed, under Related settings, select **More Windows features**.



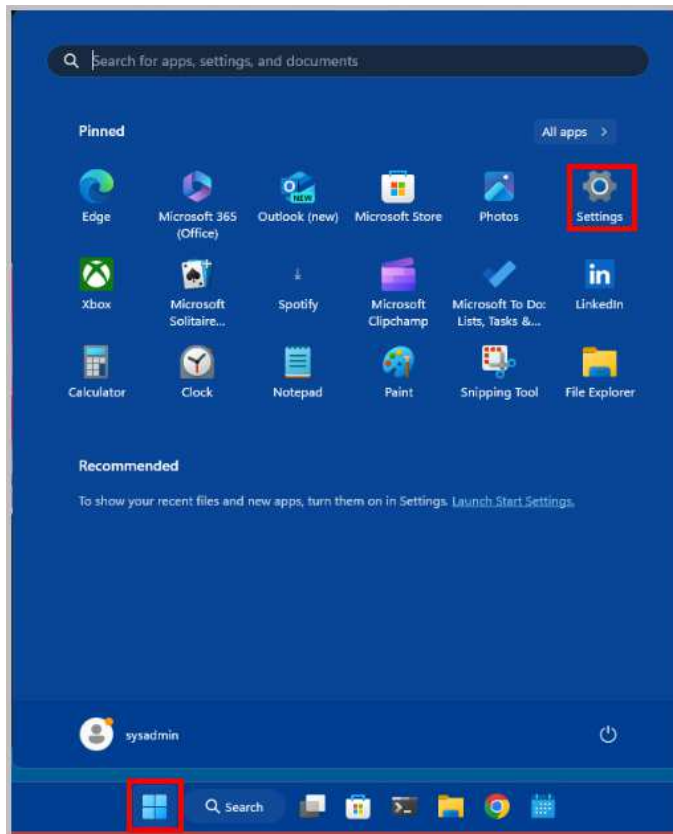
5. Review the additional Windows features that have been enabled, along with the Windows features that are available to enable. One example is that Microsoft Print to PDF has been enabled. Select **Cancel** to close the Windows Features window.



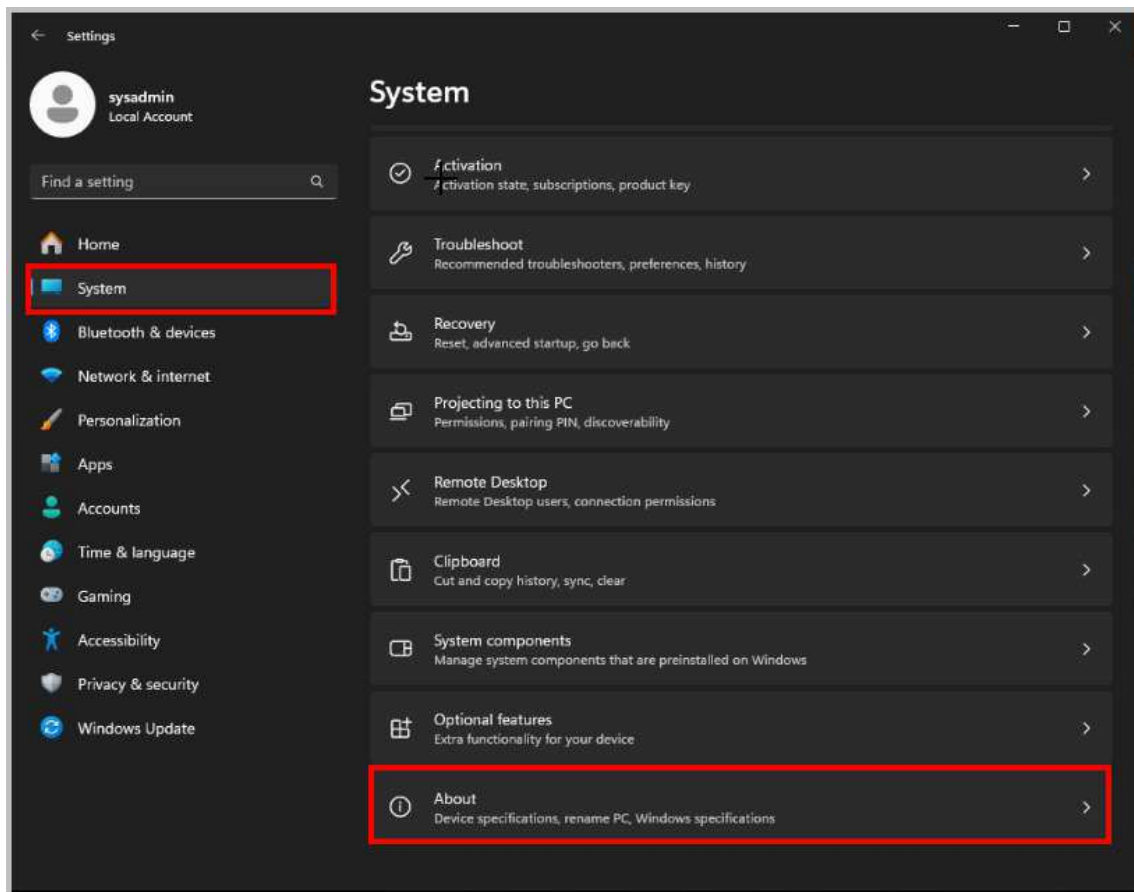
6. Close each remaining window by clicking the **X** in the top-right corner.
7. Leave the *Win11-OS* machine open to continue with the next task

4.2 Advanced System Settings in Win11-OS

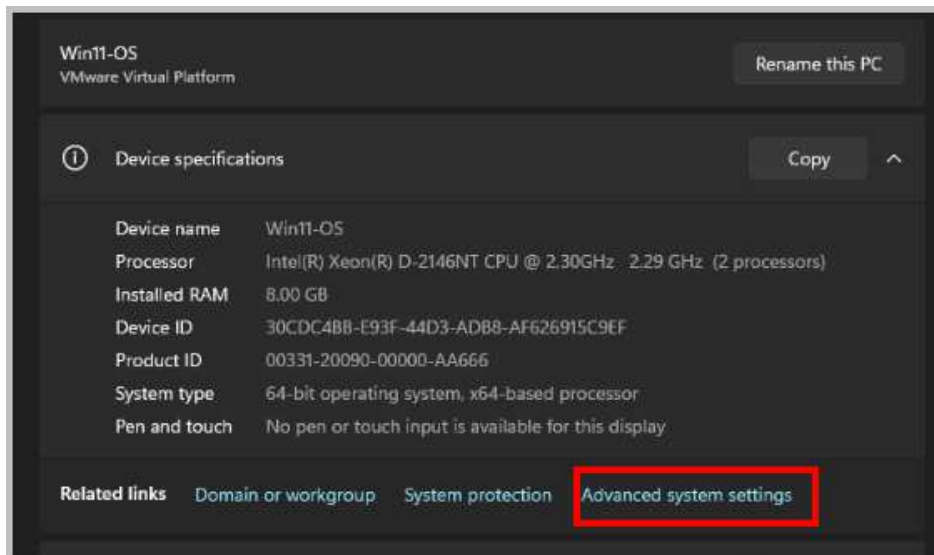
1. Select **Start**, then select **Settings**.



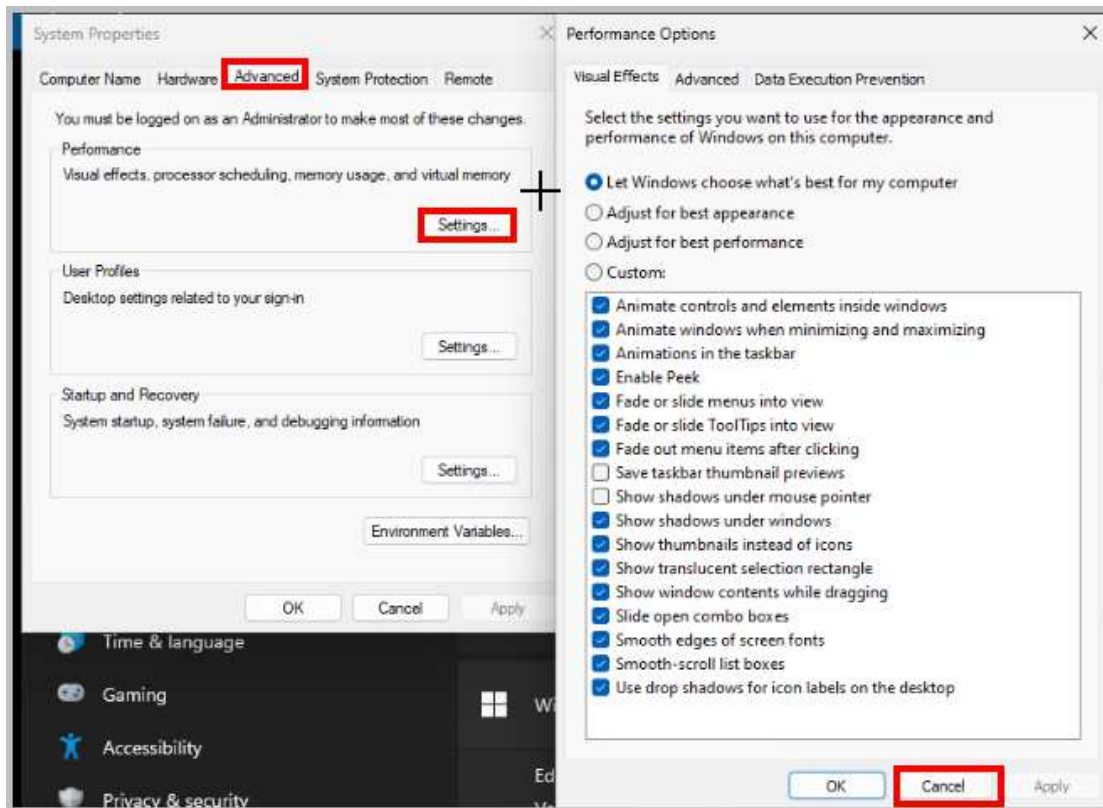
2. Select **System**. Scroll and select **About**.



3. Select **Advanced system settings**.



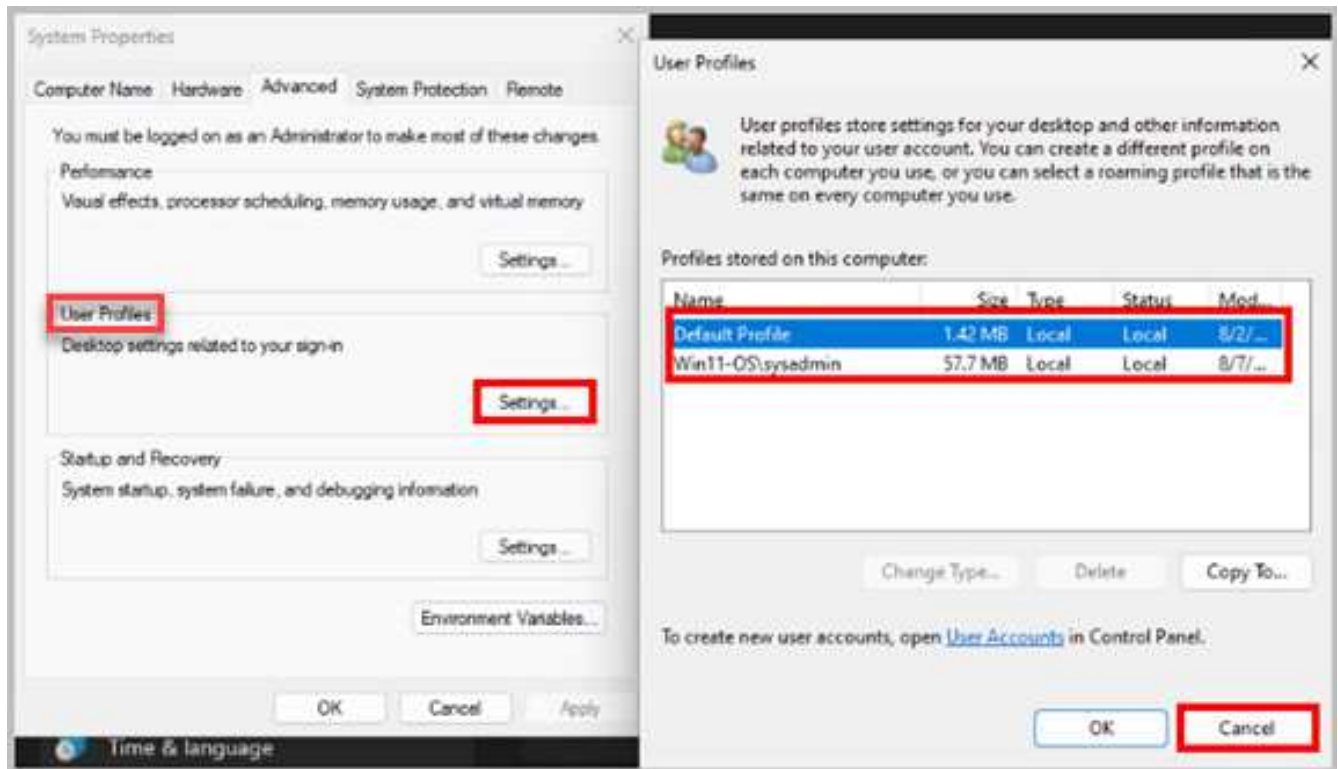
4. The System Properties window opens by default to the **Advanced** tab. Under *Performance*, select **Settings**. Review the enabled Performance Options. Once complete, select **Cancel**.



Note:

Windows 11's Advanced Performance settings allow you to fine-tune your system's appearance and speed. Adjust visual effects, background services, and processor scheduling to optimize your system's performance.

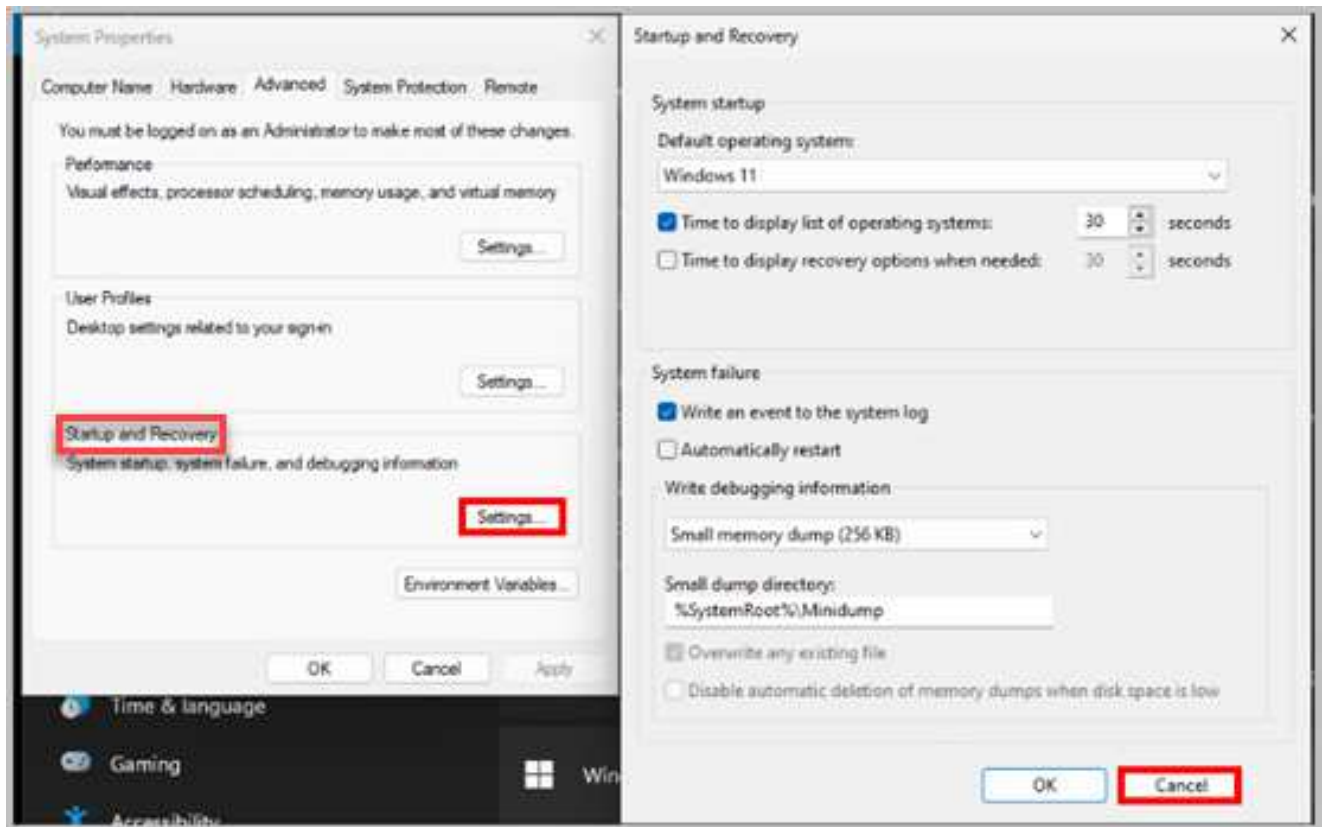
5. Under *User Profiles*, select **Settings**. Review the information on User Profiles and note the Default Profile and the Win11-OS\sysadmin accounts available. Once complete, select **Cancel**.



Note:

Windows 11's Advanced System Properties allow you to configure various system-level settings, including user profiles. Here, you can create, modify, or remove user accounts, as well as adjust their privileges.

6. Under *Startup and Recovery*, select **Settings**. Review the Startup and Recovery Options that are enabled. Once complete, select **Cancel**.

**Note:**

Windows 11's Startup and Recovery settings allow you to configure how your system behaves during startup and recovery from system failures. Here, you can set the default operating system, configure system failure options, and customize startup behavior.

7. Close each remaining window by clicking the **X** in the top-right corner.
8. The lab is now complete; you may end the reservation.